

Injured birds receive care at Carolina Raptor Center

Vultures and hawks circling overhead, owls screeching and hooting in the night, the majestic, stately eagle—all of these are raptors, or birds of prey. Raptors play a vital role in helping to maintain nature's balance. The prey they take—mice, squirrels, rabbits, etc.—if left to reproduce unchecked, could overtake and consume much of the food supply humans and other animals need to survive. In many areas of the world, populations of these birds are declining as a result of habitat loss and pollution. We humans, in our ignorance and fear, are often the cause of injury or death to these magnificent birds.

This is where the Carolina Raptor Center comes into play.

The only one of its kind in North Carolina, the Carolina Raptor Center is dedicated to the conservation of birds of prey through environmental education and the rehabilitation and release of injured or orphaned birds.

Birds received at the Center are immediately examined and treated. They are x-rayed if necessary. Volunteer veterinarians perform any needed surgery.

Rehabilitation may require a few weeks to several months, depending on the severity of the injury.

Some birds, whose injuries are too severe to allow them to survive on their own in the wild, become part of the Center's education program.

The Center has grown from its meager beginnings in 1981 in the

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basement of the biology department at UNC-Charlotte to a 57 acre environmental center which houses an educational building, gift shop and offices. Outdoors, there are aviaries along a rustic nature trail, which house more than 20 different species of live birds of prey, as well as an amphitheater and weathering area. The non-public



Bud Nofziger with Terry, a Swainson's Hawk. Terry has been a permanent resident at the Raptor Center since 1984. Mr. Nofziger is a part-time employee at the Center.

area of the Center consists of the raptor hospital and dozens of rehabilitation, breeding and flight cages for recuperating birds. Crescent EMC furnishes electricity to the hospital facility.

Over 3,500 birds of prey have been admitted to the Center since 1981. In 1991 alone, 512 birds were admitted. Approximately 45% of the birds are released yearly after they are healed. Some of the birds have gone to the Nature Museum in Charlotte, the Dan Nicholas Park in Salisbury, and many out-of-state institutions and parks.

Some of the birds which cannot be released back into the wild, live permanently at the Raptor Center. They become a part of the Center's education program, traveling to programs and exhibits with volunteers. Over 500 programs a year are conducted at the Center, in schools, for civic groups, festivals and fairs.

Pat Marcum, executive director of the Center, feels very strongly about the educational programs they offer, and in particular those which are aimed at children.

"If you can get their (children) interest when they are young, you've got them," Ms. Marcum said. "We hope that by seeing the birds up close, children will become concerned about the birds' environment and survival, and ultimately become environmentalists.

To save birds of prey, you've got to become interested in all sorts of environmental topics such as air and water quality, habitat conservation, recycling, littering, etc. All of the environmental topics across the board refer back to birds of prey," she said.

In addition to educational programs, the Raptor Center has reproduction and research programs. They also work with high school and college interns in environmental education and raptor rehabilitation.

The Carolina Raptor Center is a non-profit, tax-exempt organization. They depend solely on funds from programs, memberships, donations, grants, gift shop sales, and the Adopt-A-Bird Program. You can have a personal part in the work of the Center by becoming a member or adopting a bird. Membership categories vary from \$10 to \$200, while adoption fees range from \$25 a year to \$300 a year. Adoption donations are used to help care for the non-releasable, permanent resident birds.

Visit the Center and watch Terry, a Swainson's Hawk, spread his magnificent wings, or listen to Dumbo, a Barred Owl, hoot for you. Located in the Latta Plantation Park on Sample Road north of Charlotte, their visiting hours are Tuesday - Sunday, 10 a.m. - 5 p.m. The telephone number is (704) 875-6521.